

immediately initiated a no-confidence move against the chief minister, which prevented the Assembly from being dissolved until after the presidential elections. J's provincial legislators then resigned in a huff, to no avail, as the larger JUI members did not. The simmering tension between the two parties was out in the open, which put a question mark on the future of the Opposition religious alliance.

Two fortuitous circumstances also bolstered Musharraf's position. The first was the failure of the Sharif-led APDM in mobilising the masses to welcome the former prime minister. It made deportation of Sharif easy for the General even though it meant flouting the Supreme Court ruling which allowed him to return to Pakistan.

The second was the Supreme Court judgement throwing out the initial petitions against Musharraf's candidature and allowing the elections to be held on schedule. The 6-3 majority judgement unnerved even the lawyers' movement and many of its leading lights, who had been singing paeans to a "new independent judiciary", were reduced to questioning the motives of the apex court judges. It was a big blow to the credibility of the movement. Television commentators questioned if the lawyers were supportive of a judiciary that gave judgements only in their favour.

The coup de grâce from the Musharraf camp was the promulgation of the National Reconciliation Ordinance, which provided indemnity to the actions of politicians and bureaucrats during the "democratic decade" from 1988 to 1999. This had been one of the long-standing demands of Bhutto, who faced a number of serious corruption allegations. Coming a day before the presidential elections, the Ordinance was the surest indication that a deal had been struck between Musharraf and Bhutto. Bhutto even admitted that she had approved the text of the Ordinance.

The Ordinance, which will require ratification by the new Parliament after the general elections and which

has also been challenged in the courts, has led to a public outcry. Many, including members of the ruling Muslim League, see it as allowing the corrupt to go scot-free. Despite her attempts to justify it as not specific to a person—the Ordinance will benefit many including Sharif and members of the ruling coalition—the credibility of Bhutto and her party has been seriously damaged. Most people believe she has made a pact with the devil—compromising on their anti-military rule principles—simply to save her skin and the allegedly looted wealth.

MISSION FAILED: Sharif-led APDM could not mobilise mass support



WHILE GENERAL MUSHARRAF HAS SEEMINGLY BACKED BHUTTO, SHARIF COULD BENEFIT FROM PPP'S LOSS OF CREDIBILITY.

There is also widespread resentment at Bhutto having played into the hands of the Americans just to grab power. In two widely reported statements to the American media, she has promised that if elected to power, she would allow the International Atomic Energy Agency access to Pakistan's disgraced nuclear scientist A.Q. Khan. She has also hinted that she could allow the US forces to hunt for Osama bin Laden in Pakistan. Bhutto may have got what she wanted—US Foreign Secretary Condoleezza Rice went out of her way to express support for Bhutto's role in a future set-up—

but the reaction in Pakistan has been anything but positive. Even liberal commentators such as former ambassador Tariq Fatemi labelled her statements as "completely uncalled for".

How such perceptions impact the electoral fortunes of PPP still remains to be seen. But they do not bode well for long-term relations between Bhutto and Musharraf. In a tersely worded rejoinder to Bhutto's statements, the President discounted the possibility of such "compromises to national security."

Analysts are also questioning if Bhutto—who has been out of the country in self-imposed exile for more than

eight years—is clued in to the sea changes that have taken place in Pakistan. The same questions are valid for Sharif, if he also makes a comeback. "When they left, for example, all that existed was a state-controlled news media," says Azhar Abbas, head of Dawn News, one of over 50 new television channels. "Can they even deal with the kind of assertive, almost disrespectful, media that has mushroomed in their absence?"

For his part, Musharraf may have had his powers clipped when he agreed to step down as the army chief. But he retains the power to dismiss governments. He even said he had not changed his mind about Bhutto's misdemeanours but "the reconciliation was necessary in the larger interest of the country in order to fight the threat of extremism". With casualties mounting every day in the fight

against militants in tribal areas bordering Afghanistan, the army will play a major role in guiding elected governments in countering militancy.

PPP is hoping that the dynamics of a general election next year will make people forget Bhutto's deal-making, and are attempting to put up a brave face. Almost overnight, billboards, banners and graffiti have sprung up all over Karachi, where she is scheduled to land on October 18, welcoming her back as the "saviour of democracy and the people of Pakistan". Whether the people of Pakistan see it the same way is debatable. ■